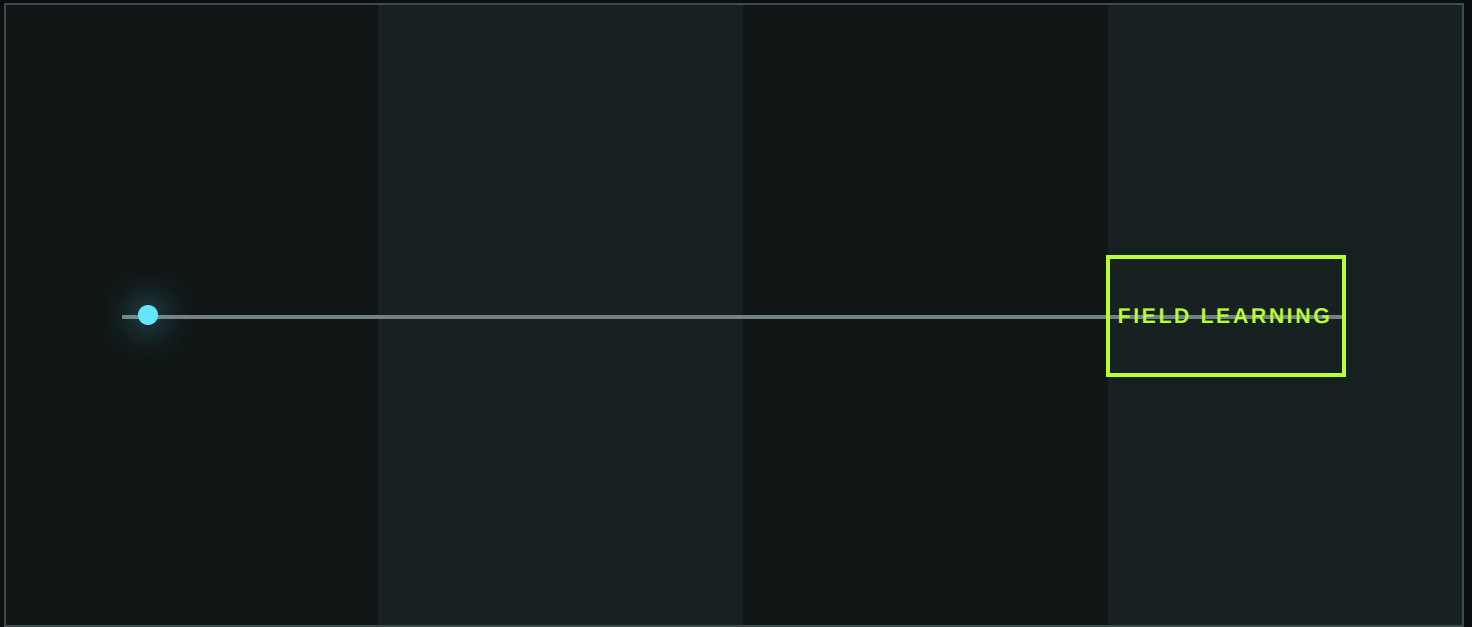




INDEPENDENT CANDIDATE ENTRY
PLAN

120 days to make portfolio decisions earlier, clearer, and more useful.

Product Associate Director (Group Product Manager)
Russell Dudek



Entry principle: tactical empathy before prescription. Read the mission and the existing product system before changing cadence, artifacts, or authority.

Candidate vision: <https://russelldudek.github.io/TwoSix/>

Read the mission and map the product system.

DAYS 1-30

Earn the right to change the operating cadence by first understanding how mission demand, product evidence, technical constraints, acquisition realities, and team craft currently meet.

OPERATING QUESTION

Where do product decisions become slow, ambiguous, expensive, or disconnected from the people doing the actual work?

Listening map

- CPO, VP Product Management, product directors, PMs, and UX leaders: portfolio intent, team autonomy, coaching needs, and decision friction.
- Engineering, AI/ML, architecture, security, test, and quality: technical dependencies, evidence thresholds, integration burden, and release constraints.
- Growth, sales, capture, contracts, and acquisition partners: buyer language, procurement path, commitments, competitive differentiation, and timing.
- Deployment, support, program, mission, and partner teams: recurring field work, operator friction, trust signals, and learning that is not yet returning to the roadmap.

Discovery lens

- Which decisions belong to product teams, portfolio leadership, platform owners, or executive sponsors?
- What evidence is considered sufficient to accelerate, scale, productize, integrate, prove, hold, or stop?
- How do open, restricted, and classified environments change discovery, testing, feedback, and support?
- Where do roadmap language, growth positioning, engineering dependencies, support burden, and acquisition path diverge?
- What product-manager and UX behaviors already work well enough to preserve and amplify?

Four diagnostic workstreams

READ BEFORE REDESIGN

WORKSTREAM	WHAT I WOULD EXAMINE	DECISION IT SHOULD IMPROVE
Portfolio truth	Strategies, roadmaps, backlogs, release decisions, product narratives, and active investment questions.	Which bets need evidence, alignment, capacity, or a clearer stop condition.
Mission and user access	Discovery channels, operator access, feedback quality, environment constraints, and proxy-user risk.	How much confidence to place in current product assumptions.
Field and integration signals	Support themes, deployment patterns, interface dependencies, recurring work, and partner handoffs.	What should remain local, become reusable, or move toward productization.
Team craft	Problem framing, evidence use, decision writing, discovery habits, UX partnership, and coaching preferences.	Where leadership attention can improve product judgment fastest.

Portfolio decision map	Named decision rights for investment, release, integration, evidence, acceleration, and stop decisions
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DAYS 31-60

Frame a minimal shared portfolio contract.

Co-create enough common structure to improve cross-product decisions without flattening product-team judgment or importing process for process's sake.

OPERATING QUESTION

What is the smallest shared decision contract that lets teams move faster while making mission value, human authority, proof, integration, acquisition, and learning visible?

Mission Window Contract

USE EXISTING LANGUAGE WHEREVER POSSIBLE

Mission outcome The user problem, operational consequence, and outcome the product must improve.	Human authority The decisions people retain, review boundaries, escalation, and fallback expectations.	Integration fit Interfaces, platforms, data, deployment environments, security, and partner dependencies.
Evidence threshold The user, technical, evaluation, trust, and operating proof needed for the next decision.	Acquisition path Buyer, procurement route, funding timing, commitment risk, and path to repeatable adoption.	Learning return How field, support, deployment, and evaluation evidence changes the roadmap or portfolio.

Three portfolio hypotheses for discovery

1

Recurring support, deployment, or integration work may reveal reusable capability that is not yet consistently visible as a portfolio investment choice.

2

Some roadmap conflict may resolve earlier when the evidence threshold, acquisition path, and dependency owner are explicit before capacity is committed.

3

AI-assisted product tradecraft may reduce synthesis and documentation burden when human review, source traceability, evaluation, and accountability remain explicit.

Qualitative baseline scorecard

- Mission outcome:** clarity of user problem and consequence.
- Product behavior:** evidence of useful, repeatable product response.
- Trust and risk:** authority, evaluation, security, fallback, and assurance.
- Adoption and support:** operator fit, deployment burden, support pattern, and partner readiness.
- Product economics:** recurring work, acquisition path, reuse, and total delivery burden.
- Learning speed:** how quickly evidence changes a decision.

Baselines would be established with the teams. No fabricated percentage, maturity score, or undisclosed internal target is assumed.

Decision rights and operating cadence

CLARITY WITHOUT CENTRALIZING EVERY CHOICE

Decision Layer	Primary Authority	Shared Evidence
Product team	Problem framing, discovery, backlog, experience, release readiness, and local learning.	Mission outcome, user evidence, technical risk, quality, and support signal.
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Portfolio leadership	Investment, capacity, cross-product leverage, platform/product boundaries	Comparable evidence thresholds, dependencies, acquisition path, economics, and learning return.



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DAYS 61-90

Prove the mechanism in live product work.

Use real decisions to test whether the shared contract improves judgment, exposes constraints earlier, strengthens team craft, and produces clearer commitments.

OPERATING QUESTION

Can a compact review improve an actual decision without creating a parallel bureaucracy, slowing teams, or replacing product judgment with a score?

First live Mission Window ReviewsILLUSTRATIVE REVIEW SET; FINAL SELECTION FOLLOWS DISCOVERY

REVIEW 01 Agentic orchestration Clarify operator outcome, tool and data authority, evaluation burden, platform dependencies, deployment posture, and the evidence needed to accelerate or hold.	REVIEW 02 Information operations Connect mission effect, analyst trust, provenance, integration, user workflow, buyer language, and repeatable product behavior.	REVIEW 03 Sensor / CBRNE decision Make field evidence, consequence, assurance, support burden, integration repeatability, acquisition path, and productization choice explicit.
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Review mechanics

- One concise pre-read: decision requested, mission outcome, evidence, dependencies, authority, acquisition path, and unresolved questions.
- A time-bounded working review focused on the decision, not a status presentation.
- One explicit disposition: accelerate, scale, productize, integrate, prove, hold, stop, or return for a named evidence gap.
- A decision record with owners, commitments, next evidence, escalation condition, and learning-return path.
- A short retrospective: what improved the decision, what added friction, and what should be simplified.

Evidence standards

- **User:** observable workflow, consequence, trust, and adoption evidence.
- **Technical:** architecture, data, interfaces, security, evaluation, quality, and failure behavior.
- **Human authority:** named review, override, escalation, and fallback.
- **Operating:** deployment, support, partner, training, and sustainment burden.
- **Commercial:** buyer, acquisition route, competitive story, commitment, and timing.
- **Learning:** what evidence would change the roadmap, investment, or product boundary.

Operating tensions to resolve in the proof cycleNAMED OWNERS AND EVIDENCE, NOT ABSTRACT DEBATE

TENSION	WORKING RESOLUTION	PROOF OUTPUT
Capacity conflict	Make mission consequence, evidence threshold, acquisition timing, and opportunity cost comparable.	Sequencing decision with owner, dependency, and revisit condition.
Platform vs. product	Separate reusable capability from product-specific operator work and integration.	Boundary decision plus reuse, ownership, support, and funding path.
Speed vs. assurance	Match evaluation, human authority, security, and fallback to consequence.	Release or proof posture with explicit assurance burden.



Institutionalize learning and set the next horizon.

DAYS 91-120

Keep only the mechanisms that improve decisions, return evidence to the portfolio, strengthen product leadership, and make recurring operating work visible as an investment choice.

OPERATING QUESTION

What must become routine so product advantage compounds after the first proof cycle instead of depending on one leader or one review?

Operating cadence to institutionalize		MINIMUM EFFECTIVE SYSTEM
Monthly	Evidence review for active portfolio hypotheses, unresolved dependencies, field/support signals, and upcoming decisions.	Decision readiness
Quarterly	Portfolio review for investment, capacity, cross-product leverage, productization, integration, proof, hold, and stop decisions.	Portfolio coherence
Biweekly	PM/UX coaching cadence using live discovery, decision writing, evidence, stakeholder, and roadmap work.	Team craft
Continuous	Field, support, deployment, evaluation, growth, and acquisition learning returned to product and platform roadmaps.	Learning return

Executive roadmap narrative

- What mission outcome each major bet is intended to improve.
- What evidence supports the bet and what remains a working hypothesis.
- What human authority, assurance, integration, and deployment constraints matter.
- What acquisition path, timing, buyer, and competitive story shape the decision.
- What dependencies and capacity commitments are required.
- What proof, stop, or revisit condition protects the portfolio.

Product economics and recurring work

- Expose recurring support, deployment, configuration, integration, training, and evaluation work.
- Separate unavoidable mission-specific work from patterns that may justify reuse, platform investment, or productization.
- Make ownership, funding, sustainment, and customer promise explicit before recurring work becomes hidden product debt.
- Connect growth opportunity to total delivery burden and support reality, not only feature demand.

120-day success evidence

VISIBLE CHANGE, WITH BASELINES ESTABLISHED FIRST

DIMENSION		WHAT SHOULD BE VISIBLY DIFFERENT
Decision clarity		Portfolio and product-team decision rights are explicit; unresolved conflicts have owners, next evidence, and escalation conditions.
Roadmap quality		Major bets show mission outcome, authority, evidence threshold, acquisition path, integration burden, dependencies, and learning return.
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Team craft		PM and UX leaders demonstrate stronger problem framing, evidence use, decision writing, and cross-